

sue a course in flying when she heard of the audition for the film *Tina ki Chabi* in Mumbai. The film centres around the character essayed by Thapa and is directed by Amit Saxena of *Jism* fame. "My heroine has oriental looks and she had to look the part. I wanted to cast someone from the North-east," says Saxena.

Life has not been easy for these achievers with people treating them as outsiders for their obvious differences.

RAVISH SAHANI



SOMDEV DEVVARMAN 24
PROFESSION Tennis player
PROVENANCE Assam

CLAIM TO FAME Beat Carlos Moya in the Chennai Open 2009. Rated as the future of Indian tennis after the Paes-Bhupathi era.

CURRENT STATUS His current ATP ranking is 127, his career best

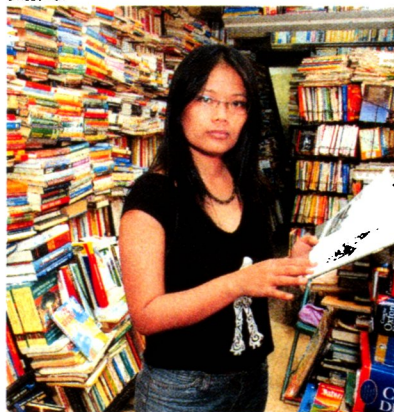
Recalls theatre director Royston Abel, "We were at the National School of Drama, Delhi in the early 1990s and Mandakini Goswami (now his wife) from Assam was not chosen to act in *Agni aur Barkha*. The director had no hesitation in telling us that it was because she did not look Indian." Today, Goswami and Adil Hussain, also from Assam, are two of the country's biggest theatre artists.

English playwright Swar Thounaojam, 28, says that discrimination exists everywhere and that she has learnt to accept it as part of life. "I've been stalked and asked how much I charge for a night. Bottles were thrown at me for not responding to being called *chinky*," she says. The first play that she wrote, *Turel*, was directed by renowned theatre director Sunil Shanbag. Thounaojam, who was selected for the Writer's Bloc Playwrights Residency conducted by

the Royal Court Theatre in 2007, feels that the North-east is finally breaking some barriers. "It's probably because so many of us travel outside the states to study or to work," says Thounaojam who is now working with professionals in Munich, learning the intricacies of lighting design.

While language was a dividing factor earlier, today the North-east has a greater exposure to Hindi. Something that Agatha Sangma, 28, the youngest

GIREESH GV



SWAR THOUNAOJAM 28
PROFESSION Writer, playwright

PROVENANCE Manipur

CLAIM TO FAME Was selected for the Writer's Bloc Playwrights Residency by the Royal Court Theatre in 2007

CURRENT STATUS Writing and developing two new projects

reers that were once considered unconventional." Such as that of Parishmita Singh, 29, who drew inspiration from two folk characters from Assam, Kana and Kuja, to write her first graphic novel, *The Hotel at the End of the World*.

And therein lies the difference. "It's been happening for a while now. The more the youngsters choose popular careers and are covered by the media, the more they help in bridging the gap between us who live in the hills and mainstream India," says noted Naga sociologist C.J. Wazah. If Bhutia has been the Indian football's biggest star for more than a decade, Assam-born Somdev Devvarman is the new star of Indian tennis. Mangte Chungneijang Merykom, also known as Mary Kom, may not be as popular as Bhutia and Devvarman, but the 27-year-old boxer from Manipur made the country proud by becoming the first woman to win the world title three years in a row after the championships were introduced in the United States in 2001.

As Dutta expands her repertoire by taking acting lessons at Anupam Kher's academy and Saha and Debbarma croon to a roaring crowd, one can't help wondering: why did it take so long?

with Kaushik Deka